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says something about Hanoi's changing position in the travel market. It is no longer only a stop for backpackers. It is now a city where luxury travellers linger.

Food is central to this transformation. Hanoi's street food remains spectacular, and no visit feels complete without *bun cha*—a dish of grilled pork patties and pork belly served with rice vermicelli, herbs, and dipping sauce. Bun Cha Huong Lien became globally famous after Barack Obama ate there with Anthony Bourdain in 2016, and today the restaurant remains a pilgrimage site, with photographs of Obama



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PHOTO BY ALAMY

displayed proudly and regular queues outside.

Coffee is another Hanoi essential. Vietnam is the world's second-largest coffee exporter and a major producer of robusta. At Giang Café in the Old Quarter, egg coffee is the star: egg yolks whipped with sugar and condensed milk into a creamy foam layered over strong black coffee. Rich, sweet, and almost dessert-like, it is one of the city's most memorable rituals.

Yet Hanoi's food scene is no longer only about street stalls and family cafés. In 2023, the Michelin Guide launched its first Vietnam edition, covering Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City. By 2025, Vietnam had nine Michelin-starred restaurants. In Hanoi, Tam Vi stands out, offering North Vietnamese cuisine in a vintage tea-house setting with a lush courtyard, antique décor, English-speaking staff, and a tourist-friendly photo menu.

This is Hanoi's great charm. While it is still a city of backpackers, scooters, *bia hoi* (beer), and crowded lanes, it is also home to luxury hotels, destination restaurants, and premium flights arriving full. **BT**